Drama & exam writing

Notice the stage

1 What an audience knows

Duncan: trusts the welcome

Audience: knows the plot

Unequal knowledge → tension

Soliloquy: private thoughts. Aside: concealed from other characters. Dramatic irony: audience knows what a character does not.

Track contrasts between public behaviour and private speech, rather than treating the play as a novel.

2 How the action is staged

Duncan's murder is offstage: anticipation and aftermath dominate. Macduff's family faces violence onstage.

Knocking interrupts the murder aftermath. Banquet shifts from ceremony to chaos.

Explain why the order and staging matter.

Build close analysis

3 Sound, form & imagery

Much speech is blank verse; rhythmic patterns can vary. Witches' rhyme can sound ritual-like.

Lady Macbeth's fragmented sleepwalking prose contrasts with earlier control.

Blood, sleep, darkness and clothing develop repeated ideas; explain effects, not just technique names.

4 15-mark extract

About 20 minutes. Give a clear overview, then follow changes across the printed passage.

Short evidence → precise word/action analysis → meaning → possible audience response.

Keep focus on this passage; avoid retelling the whole play.

Develop an argument

5 25-mark essay

About 40 minutes. 20 literary marks + 5 for writing accuracy. Plan a clear answer and three/four developing moments.

Link beginning, middle and end; show how Shakespeare presents the idea.

Use connected paragraphs and accurate quotation or clear event references.

6 Flexible evidence

"Vaulting ambition": excess and judgement. "Fruitless crown": insecurity. "Little water" → "damned spot": reversal and guilt.

"Feel it as a man": grief and courage. "Walking shadow": emptiness.

Explain evidence in its moment, then link it to the argument.